refused: it was a Hindustani belief, he said, that a lion to the left was a good sign. They rode on.

It wasn't just omens, but a miracle, too, that paved Akbar's way to his unsuspecting enemy. On 29 August 1573, they were still a day's hard ride from Ahmedabad, but Akbar's men wanted to stop a while in Jhotana, a small fortress the Fuladis had occupied. Akbar didn't see the point of it – to have ridden in such fury for such a small prize? It was the Mirza in Ahmedabad he was after, and the Mirza in Ahmedabad he would have. They were arguing when a bullet from Jhotana struck a soldier standing by Akbar's side. The man cried in alarm but when they checked they found him unharmed. It was 'the neighbourhood of the holy personality', writes Abul Fazl, that saved him.

A bullet failing to injure its mark was no oddity in these early years of ballistic technology. Only a few years earlier, in Chittorgarh, a bullet had hit a man standing near Akbar, pierced his armour but then, cooled by the sweat on his skin, failed to detonate. Then, Abul Fazl attributed the miracle to science and God, in more or less equal measure; now, the soldier's safekeeping was Akbar's doing alone.

Were people really beginning to believe that Akbar was superhuman? The thought may well have crossed Mirza Muhammad Husain's mind, happily preoccupied with the siege of Ahmedabad, when he heard the padishah had arrived. The Mirza was on a recce along the Sabarmati river when he saw Akbar's scout on the opposite bank. Expecting reinforcements from Fuladi and seeing a fellow Central Asian instead, Muhammad Husain called out across the waters. *Who are you?*

At the scout's reply, he might have rolled his eyes. 'O brother, are you frightening me . . .?'

No. It really was true, said the scout. Akbar was here. Mirza Muhammad Husain demanded to see elephants, troops, any proof at all, but received the same reply: Akbar had arrived. If the Mirza didn't want to believe it . . .

Muhammad Husain waited no more. He 'hastened to his own camp' and began to array his troops.[47]

Akbar was getting his own men ready, meanwhile; no easy task, when a soldier's pride must be as carefully tended as his sword. Trouble arose over a breastplate; specifically a breastplate that a young warrior called Jaimal